Hook & Horizon — Detailed Progression & Questline Blueprint

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1) Progression Map (Acts → Milestones)

Act I — First Casts (Starter Isles)

Theme: Arrival & learning.
Target playtime: 45–90 minutes.
Player verbs: move, cast, hook mini-game, sell, mark map, accept simple quests.

Systems unlocked

- Fishing Core (cast → react → catch → weigh → keep/sell)
- Basic fishing rod (wooden rod)
- Inventory & weight; Camp storage (small chest)
- Map + player markers + notes
- Basic Merchant (sell fish, buy bait/basic rod)

Soft gates in play

- Fragile inflateable boat (dinghy) (low speed/HP) blocks rough waters
- Night visibility & basic enemies (seagulls/reef eels) encourage day travel

Critical quests (Harbor Guild 1–4)

1. *Welcome Ashore*: Catch 3 fish; learn sell loop → **Reward**: Coins + Map markers.
2. *Lines & Knots*: Perform 3 perfect hooks → **Reward**: Coins + bait.
3. *Tide Etiquette*: Explore a new biome; return safely → **Reward**: **Backpack +4 slots**.
4. *First Delivery*: Timed delivery to Lighthouse → **Reward**: **access cannoe (+15% Speed bonus)**, unlock **Bounty Board** tier 1.

Milestone: Fish Log page 1, 1st backpack upgrade, Bounty tier 1, safe coastal loop.

Act II — Coastal Network

Theme: Charting coasts & errands.
Target playtime: 2–3 hours.

Systems unlocked

- Bounty Board (repeatables scale with biome)
- Small rod upgrades (Casting rods, spinning rods)

- Waypoints & Camps (quick rest; not fast travel yet)
- Weather v1 (rain, clear; minor biome multipliers)

Soft gates in play

- Strong currents sections need better hull/engine
- Cold snaps at night drain stamina faster (carry campfire kit)

Critical quests (Harbor Guild 5–8)

5. *Courier's Route*: Catch 10 different fish→ **Reward**: **Rowboat (+15% HP bo**nus), new shop offers.
6. *Supply Chain*: Deliver bait crates in light rain → **Reward**: Coins + bait.
7. *Survey Contract*: Place 3 coastal beacons → **Reward**: Compass.
8. *Guild Credential*: Catch any 5 species across 2 biomes → **Reward**: Temporary shop discount **20%**, **Boat upgrade permit**.

Milestone: Coastal lanes mapped; Minimap active; Boat Level 2 available.

Act III — Engines & Elements

Theme: Specialized tools, reaching rougher waters.
Target playtime: 3–4 hours.

Systems unlocked

- Rod specializations (Shock Rod, Soulcatcher Mod, etc.)
- Boat Tier 2 (keel, small engine); Boat fenders (+HP upgrade)
- Seasons v1 (Spring/Summer; gentle multipliers)

Soft gates in play

- Deeper waters require **Sonar Ping** consumable (craft)
- Night predators on open sea (avoidance or flare consumable)

Critical quests (Tideworks Restoration 1–3)

1. *Echoes of the Tideworks*: Scan an ancient node → **Reward**: **Sonar recipe**.
2. *Calibration Samples*: Provide catches from 3 distinct biomes (Rarity > Rare) → **Reward**: temporary luck charm **+25% luck**
3. *Big Load*: Deliver 500kg of fish to the Harbor Guild. **Reward**: Coins
4. *Stabilize the Spindle*: Escort a researcher skiff → **Reward**: new shop offers.

Milestone: Access to deeper coasts, basic element interactions, first Tidework stabilized (minor world buff).

Act IV — The Burning Rim (Volcanic Approach)

Theme: Heat management, geothermals, dramatic vistas.
Target playtime: 3–4 hours.

Systems unlocked

- Heat/Environmental thresholds & salves
- **Lava Rod** for catching extra fish with the '*Burning*' mutation
- Enemy avoidance mastery (nets, traps)

Soft gates in play

- Volcanic lanes require **Engine Cooler**
- Geyser timing puzzles; wind shifts open/close safe windows

Critical quests (Burning Permit 1–4)

1. *Ash on the Wind*: Gather herbs → **Reward**: Magma bait recipe.
2. *Coolant Loop*: Fix an engine condenser → **Reward**: Boat Engine Cooler (+20% Speed bonus).
3. *The Barge Through Fire*: Escort a miner barge through vents → **Reward**: Lava Rod.
4. *Vulcanic* seismometer: Place *seismometer* at vulcano rim → **Reward**: **totem fast travel (Costs coins)**.

Milestone: Volcanic biome safely approachable; limited fast-travel between your beacons.

Act V — The Long Horizon (Endgame Loop)

Theme: Mastery, mutations, leaderboards, prestige voyages.
Target playtime: Infinite loop.

Systems unlocked

- Boat Tier 3 (cruiser)
- Full Seasons & Advanced Weather (storms, fog)
- Specific Mutation Baits (golden, rainbow, phantom, nuclear variants)
- High-tier Bounties & World Events

Soft gates in play

- Storm corridors require **Storm Sails** or waiting for forecast window
- Deep trench gates require **Pressure Hull** + **Sonar Mk2**

Critical quests (Tideworks 4–6, Depth's Due 1–3)

- *Pulse of the Depths*: Chart trench, bea leviathan → **Reward**: ***Player mutation skin***.

- *Horizon Calibrator*: Deliver diverse catches during specific weather windows → **Reward**: **World event control lever** (minor).
- *The Long Circuit*: Complete a grand voyage (multi-biome relay) → **Reward**: **Prestige cosmetics/ledger**.

Milestone: Fully open world, rotating events, prestige voyages, optional competitive boards.

2) Core Questlines (Step-by-step)

A) Harbor Guild — Onboarding Chain (8 steps)

1. **Welcome Ashore** (Act I): Catch 3 fish and sell them; place a map marker. → **Rewards**: Coins, **Map markers** unlocked.
2. **Lines & Knots** (Act I): Perform 3 perfect hooks. → **Rewards**: Coins, bait bundle.
3. **Tide Etiquette** (Act I): Visit an adjacent biome and return safely at dusk. → **Rewards**: **Backpack +4 slots**.
4. **First Delivery** (Act I): Timed run to the Lighthouse. → **Rewards**: **Canoe access (+15% speed)**, **Bounty Board Tier 1**.
5. **Courier's Route** (Act II): Chart a safe lane past reefs and make a delivery. → **Rewards**: **Hull Patch (+HP)**, new shop stock.
6. **Supply Chain** (Act II): Deliver bait crates during light rain. → **Rewards**: **Rain Tarp** (reduced stamina drain in rain).
7. **Survey Contract** (Act II): Place 3 coastal **beacons** and return a sketch. → **Rewards**: **Compass & Minimap**.
8. **Guild Credential** (Act II): Catch any 5 species across **2 biomes**. → **Rewards**: **5% merchant discount**, **Boat Tier-2 permit**.

B) Tideworks Restoration — Main Chain (6 steps)

1. **Echoes of the Tideworks** (Act III): Scan an ancient node. → **Rewards**: **Sonar recipe**.
2. **Calibration Samples** (Act III): Provide catches from **3 distinct biomes** (Rarity > Rare). → **Rewards**: Temporary Luck Charm +25%.
3. **Big Load:** Deliver 500kg worth of fish to the Harbour Guild. **Reward**: Coins
4. **Stabilize the Spindle** (Act III): Escort a researcher skiff through rough water. → **Rewards**: New shop offers.
5. **Pulse of the Depth** (Act V): Chart the threnches, beat the Leviathan → **Rewards**: ***Player Mutation skin***.
6. **Horizon Calibrator** (Act V): Deliver samples with specific mutations/buffs. → **Rewards**: World event control lever (minor).
7. **The Long Circuit** (Act V): Complete a Grand Voyage (explore all biomes). → **Rewards**: **Prestige cosmetics/ledger.**

C) Burning Permit — Volcanic Access (4 steps)

1. **Ash on the Wind** (Act IV): Gather herbs and craft a prototype salve. → **Rewards**: **Heat Salve recipe**.
2. **Coolant Loop** (Act IV): Repair an engine condenser. → **Rewards**: **Engine Cooler mod**.
3. **The Barge Through Fire** (Act IV): Escort the miner barge through vent lanes. → **Rewards**: **Lava Rod**.
4. **Vulcanic Seismometer** (Act IV): Place a seismometer at the volcano rim. → **Rewards**: **Limited fast travel between placed beacons (costs fuel/coins)**.

D) Depth's Due — Hazard Mastery (3 steps)

1. **Hull Breach Drill** (Act V): Practice emergency repairs. → **Rewards**: **Repair speed buff**.
2. **Predator Evasion** (Act V): Cross an open-sea corridor at night. → **Rewards**: **Flare/Decoy recipes**.
3. **Trench Mapping** (Act V): Chart a deep trench corridor. → **Rewards**: **Pressure Hull unlock**.

E) Bounty Board — Repeatables (All Acts)

- Contracts scale by distance, weather, and act. Rewards: coins, materials, cosmetics. Special **migratory hotspot** bounties can temporarily boost certain species anywhere (no exclusivity).